The Five Breakpoints

The five predictable failure patterns of large-scale change, and a question that detects each one before drift becomes expensive.

Organizations rarely fail to transform for lack of activity. More often, the initiative was not designed to withstand the pressures that large-scale change creates. The same five breakpoints appear in AI adoption and operating-model redesign alike, and each one is a visible sign that a force the change depends on has weakened.



1 Strategic Disconnection

POINTS TO PURPOSE

Leaders hear the same language repeated back and assume alignment, while each team fills in its own definition of success.

DETECTION QUESTION

If you asked ten leaders to describe the primary outcome of the initiative, would their answers match?

2 Incentive Fragmentation

POINTS TO COMMITMENT

People attend the meetings, then go back to the priorities they are paid on.

DETECTION QUESTION

If the initiative succeeds but a leader's own metrics do not improve, will that leader still treat the work as a priority?

3 Process Friction

POINTS TO CAPABILITY

Teams are told to move faster through the same handoffs and approvals, and the strategy gets negotiated one handoff at a time.

DETECTION QUESTION

If you mapped how work flows today, would it look like the formal process or the workaround your teams built to survive it?

4 The Technology Illusion

POINTS TO CAPABILITY

The new tool is live, and the work still happens the old way around it.

DETECTION QUESTION

If you removed the technology tomorrow, would teams still agree on how the work should happen?

5 Momentum Mirage

POINTS TO MOMENTUM

The steering committee meets less often while the status stays green, and people quietly return to local priorities.

DETECTION QUESTION

What would happen if you stopped actively managing this initiative for 90 days?

THE FORCES UNDERNEATH

Each breakpoint maps to a force.

Strategic Disconnection usually points to weak Purpose, and Incentive Fragmentation exposes weak Commitment. Process Friction and the Technology Illusion both reveal Capability gaps. Momentum Mirage is what happens when reinforcement fades before the organization has shifted. The breakpoint tells you where the pain is surfacing, and the force explains what must change.

HOW TO USE THE QUESTIONS

Ask the people doing the work.

Put the five questions to the teams carrying the change as well as to the people running it, and compare the answers. A weak answer to any one shows where the initiative is likely to stall. A condition you can name is a condition you can fix, and the fix costs far less early than after the post-mortem.